

VERBS LIKE GUSTAR I

— Essential Guide

Understanding the Basic Structure

A1–A2

1 How does gustar work?

Compare these two sentences:

I like pizza.

Me gusta la pizza.

They communicate a similar idea, but they do not have the same grammatical structure. In English, I is the subject of like. In Spanish, la pizza is the subject of gustar. The person who experiences the feeling is represented by an indirect object pronoun.

Part	Function
me	indirect object pronoun: the person who experiences the feeling
gusta	verb
la pizza	subject

The verb agrees with the subject:

Me gusta la pizza.

Me gustan las pizzas.

2 Who experiences the feeling?

The indirect object pronoun tells us who experiences the feeling.

Person	Pronoun	Example
I	me	Me gusta la pizza.
you	te	Te gusta la pizza.
he / she / you (formal)	le	Le gusta la pizza.
we	nos	Nos gusta la pizza.
they / you all	les	Les gusta la pizza.

The pronoun is an essential part of this structure. You do not normally need to add a mí, a ti, a él, etc. These sentences are complete:

Me gusta la pizza.

Te gustan los perros.

Nos gusta viajar.

3 When do we use a mí, a ti, etc.?

Expressions such as a mí, a ti, a él, a ella, a nosotros and a ellos are useful when we want to create contrast or emphasis.

Contrast

A Juan le gusta la pizza.

A mí me gustan las tortas.

Emphasis

A mí me encanta esta película.

Without contrast or emphasis, the indirect object pronoun is usually enough:

Me gusta la pizza.

4 Identifying a specific person

Le and les can refer to many different people. If we want to identify the specific person, we introduce that person with a.

A María **le** gusta **la** pizza.

Al perro **le** gustan **los** huesos.

A mis padres **les** gusta **viajar**.

Specific person	Pronoun	Verb	Subject
A María	le	gusta	la pizza
Al perro	le	gustan	los huesos
A mis padres	les	gusta	viajar

Two rules matter:

1. The specific person is introduced with a.

✗ **María** le gusta la pizza.

✓ **A** María le gusta la pizza.

2. We still use le or les.

✗ **A** María gusta la pizza.

✓ **A** María le gusta la pizza.

The phrase beginning with a identifies the person. It does not replace the indirect object pronoun.

5 Gusta or gustan?

The verb agrees with its subject.

Subject	Verb
la película	gusta
las películas	gustan
el perro	gusta
los perros	gustan

Do not choose gusta or gustan according to how many people experience the feeling:

A mis amigos **les gusta la película.**

A María **le gustan las películas.**

6 Don't forget the article

English and Spanish use articles differently. In English we can say I like pizza or I like dogs. In Spanish, when we talk about these things as general categories, we normally use the definite article.

✗ Me gusta pizza.

✓ Me gusta la pizza.

✗ Me gustan perros.

✓ Me gustan los perros.

The noun can also have another determiner or quantifier:

Me gusta esta película.

Me gustan mis zapatos.

Me gustan algunas películas mexicanas.

The important point is not to automatically copy the English structure and omit the determiner.

7 Gustar + an infinitive

When the subject is an activity expressed with an infinitive, use the singular form:

Me gusta correr.

A María le gusta cocinar.

Me encanta cantar.

8 Two or more infinitives

The singular is also used when two or more coordinated infinitives function together as the subject:

Me gusta correr y nadar.

A María le gusta cocinar y viajar.

✓ **Me gusta correr y nadar.**

✗ **Me gustan correr y nadar.**

This is why the simple rule “one thing = gusta, several things = gustan” is not always useful.

9 Two or more singular nouns

When two or more singular nouns come after gustar, singular agreement is very common in everyday Spanish:

Me gusta el té y el café.

You may also see plural agreement: **Me gustan el té y el café.**

Both forms are correct. The plural follows the regular agreement rule for a coordinated subject, while the singular is very common in everyday spoken Spanish.

10 Other verbs that use this pattern

Once you understand the structure with *gustar*, you can recognize the same grammatical pattern with many other verbs.

Type	Examples
Preferences, interests and reactions	Me encanta esta ciudad. Me interesan los idiomas. Me importa tu opinión. Me molesta el ruido. Me preocupa el examen.
Physical sensations	Me duele la cabeza. Me duelen las piernas. Me pican los ojos.
Quantity, availability and need	Me falta tiempo. Me faltan diez pesos. Me queda una hora. Me sobran dos boletos.
Events	Me pasó algo extraño. Me pasaron muchas cosas. Me sucedió algo interesante.

The exact meaning changes, but the same basic grammatical relationship can appear:

Indirect object pronoun	Verb	Subject
me	gusta	la pizza
me	interesan	los idiomas
me	duele	la cabeza
me	faltan	diez pesos
me	pasó	algo extraño

11 Don't translate a formula — understand the Spanish structure

You may have heard that gustar “works backwards” compared with English. That comparison can be useful at first, but it should not become a general rule.

Spanish	Natural English
Me gustan los perros.	I like dogs.
Me duelen las piernas.	My legs hurt.
Me pasó algo extraño.	Something strange happened to me.

What remains consistent is the Spanish analysis: identify the indirect object pronoun, the verb and the subject. The Spanish structure is more reliable than a translation formula.

12 Common mistakes

Incorrect	Correct	Why?
× Me gusta perros.	✓ Me gustan los perros.	Los perros is plural and needs the article.
× Me gustan correr y nadar.	✓ Me gusta correr y nadar.	Coordinated infinitives use singular here.
× María le gusta la pizza.	✓ A María le gusta la pizza.	The specific person is introduced with a.
× A María gusta la pizza.	✓ A María le gusta la pizza.	The indirect object pronoun is required.
× A mis amigos le gusta viajar.	✓ A mis amigos les gusta viajar.	Les refers to mis amigos.

13 The main idea

Do not memorize gustar simply as gusta = one thing and gustan = several things. Instead, ask two questions:

1. Who experiences it? → me / te / le / nos / les
2. What is the subject? → the verb agrees with this element.

A María le gustan los perros.

Question	Answer
Who experiences the feeling?	María
How is María represented?	le
What is the subject?	los perros
Singular or plural?	plural
Therefore...	gustan

Person	Pronoun	Subject	Verb
I	me	la película	gusta
you	te	las películas	gustan
he / she / you (formal)	le	el perro	gusta
we	nos	los perros	gustan
they / you all	les		